



The Lady Vanishes

Directed by: Alfred Hitchcock

Production Company: Gainsborough Pictures

Presented by: Gaumont-British Picture Corporation

Screenplay: Sidney Gilliat, Frank Launder

Continuity: Alma Reville

Based upon the novel The Wheel Spins *by:*

Ethel Lina White

Director of Photography: Jack Cox

Editing: R.E. Dearing

Cutting: Alfred Roome

Settings: Vetchinsky

Musical Director: Louis Levy

Recording: S. Wiles

Sound Recorded on:

British Acoustic Full Range System

Sound Recorded at: Gainsborough Studios

Made at: Gainsborough Studios

uncredited

Producer: Edward Black

1st Assistant Director: Tom D. Connochie

2nd Assistant Director: Roy Ward Baker

Assistant Cameraman: Len Harris

Location Photography: Jack Parry, Maurice Oakley

Assistant Art Directors: Maurice Carter,

Albert Jullion

Music: Cecil Milner

Cast:

Margaret Lockwood (*Iris Matilda Henderson*)

Michael Redgrave (*Gilbert Redman*)

Paul Lukas (*Dr Egon Hartz*)

Dame May Whitty (*Miss Froy*)

Cecil Parker (*Eric Todhunter*)

Linden Travers (*Margaret, 'Mrs Todhunter'*)

Mary Clare (*Baroness*)

Naunton Wayne (*Caldicott*)

Basil Radford (*Charters*)

Emile Boreo (*Boris, hotel manager*)

Googie Withers (*Blanche*)

Sally Stewart (*Julie*)

Philip Leaver (*Signor Doppo*)

Zelma Vas Dias (*Signora Doppo*)

Catherine Lacy (*the nun*)

Josephine Wilson (*Madame Kummer*)

Charles Oliver (*the officer*)

Kathleen Tremaine (*Anna, the hotel maid*)

uncredited

Alfred Hitchcock (*man at Victoria railway station*)

UK 1938©

96 mins

Digital

Become a BFI Member

Enjoy a great package of film benefits including priority booking at BFI Southbank and BFI Festivals. Join today at bfi.org.uk/join

Sight and Sound

Never miss an issue with **Sight and Sound**, the BFI's internationally renowned film magazine. Subscribe from just £25*

* Price based on a 6-month print subscription (UK only). More info:

sightandsoundsubs.bfi.org.uk/subscribe

SIGHT and SOUND

Station to Station: Kazuo Ishiguro's Top Ten Train Films

The Lady Vanishes

On a train crossing Europe on the brink of the Second World War, Iris takes tea with the friendly English governess she met in her compartment. Minutes later, the governess has vanished and none of the train's eccentric gallery of passengers will admit to having ever seen her. Propelled by a superb Launder and Gilliat script, Hitchcock's finest British film is, by turns, hilarious, thrilling, romantic and scary.

Kazuo Ishiguro

This was a railway coupling made in dreamtime. In Alfred Hitchcock's *The Lady Vanishes*, Margaret Lockwood and Michael Redgrave, playing a London socialite and her admirer on a trans-European express carrying a smorgasbord of Axis conspirators, brought a sexy screwball frisson to the staid British cinema of the late 1930s. England may have been 'on the brink', but the blinkered English weren't prepared to let imminent war divert them from their passions. Two quintessential Englishmen, Charters (Basil Radford) and Caldicott (Naunton Wayne), fret about making it to a Manchester Test Match on time. The musical folklorist Gilbert (Redgrave) frets about making it with Iris Henderson (Lockwood) before she marries for money a few days hence. Iris frets about Miss Froy (Dame May Whitty), the tweedy governess whose disappearance shortly after departure indicates foul play.

It's tempting to seek topicality in the appeasement theme, the espionage plot and the film's meditation on Englishness, but none of these elements resonates much today. What does is Hitchcock's manipulation of Iris' consciousness and, through the use of the train as a vehicle for dreaming, the idea that she, not Miss Froy (the literal disappearee), is the lady who vanishes. Then there's her banter with Gilbert – the kind of droll to-and-fro sadly missing from contemporary comedy. Back projection, process shots, transparencies, archival footage, railway noises and wisps of steam drifting through an open window give a semblance of realism to the train itself – probably the Arlberg Orient Express – but modern audiences understand that it never existed outside a sound stage.

Launder and Gilliat adapted *The Lady Vanishes* from Ethel Lina White's tepid 1936 novel *The Wheel Spins*, which had followed Graham Greene's *Stamboul Train* and Agatha Christie's *Murder on the Orient Express* into bookstores. For all its low-key visual artifice, it's the most iconic entry in the British train-film cycle of the 1930s – in cinematic terms, the golden age of steam. *The Lady Vanishes* is cosmopolitan and predicated on speed – of narrative, wit, motion and emotion.

The advent of talkies and the glamour of continental rail travel, which was being democratised in the early 1930s, may explain the vogue for train movies in the manner of *Boule de suif*, Guy de Maupassant's archetypal travel short story about a group of disparate characters reacting to a crisis. Such films include Walter Forde's *Rome Express* (1932), co-written by Gilliat, and Paul Martin's *Orient Express* (1933), based on *Stamboul Train*. The Hollywood exemplar is *Shanghai Express* (1932), filmed by Josef von Sternberg at Paramount and on a stretch of the Santa Fe line with a thousand Asian extras; for *The Lady Vanishes* Hitchcock had to make do with a 90-foot set on a small stage at Islington Studios.

Gilliat also contributed dialogue to the 1931 film of *The Ghost Train*, directed by Forde, as was the 1941 remake. There was the 1935 thriller *Night Mail*, and Harry Watt and Basil Wright's lyrical 1936 GPO documentary of the same name. Launder and Gilliat first teamed to write *Seven Sinners* (1936), which

Station to Station: Kazuo Ishiguro's Top Ten Train Films

Rome Express

Wed 1 Jul 20:50; Tue 21 Jul 18:15 (+ intro with writer Jonathan Coe, hosted by writer and season curator Kazuo Ishiguro)

Shanghai Express

Thu 2 Jul 20:40 (+ intro by writer and season curator Kazuo Ishiguro); Sat 11 Jul 12:00; Thu 16 Jul 18:30

Compartment No. 6

Hytti nro 6
Sat 4 Jul 20:40; Mon 20 Jul 18:20; Wed 29 Jul 20:45

The Lady Vanishes

Sun 5 Jul 12:00; Fri 17 Jul 20:30

Murder on the Orient Express

Mon 6 Jul 20:25; Sun 26 Jul 14:20 (+ intro with writer Sophie Hannah, hosted by writer and season curator Kazuo Ishiguro)

Night Train

Pociąg
Tue 7 Jul 18:10 (+ intro with Professor Philip Horne, hosted by Kazuo Ishiguro); Wed 15 Jul 17:50

Snowpiercer

Fri 10 Jul 20:30; Fri 24 Jul 18:10; Mon 27 Jul 20:30

Runaway Train

Sat 11 Jul 18:20; Sat 18 Jul 20:40

TransSiberian

Sat 18 Jul 12:15; Wed 22 Jul 18:20; Fri 31 Jul 20:40

Tickets

Thu 23 Jul 18:10; Thu 30 Jul 20:40

BFI Player

We are always open online on BFI Player where you can watch the best new, cult & classic cinema on demand. Showcasing hand-picked landmark British and independent titles, films are available to watch in three distinct ways: Subscription, Rentals & Free to view.

See something different today on player.bfi.org.uk

25 & Under

We want to open up great independent and classic film and TV for all, making it as accessible as possible. If you are under the age of 26, you can get discounted tickets for BFI Southbank and BFI Festivals. BFI Southbank cinema tickets are £4, with festival tickets £6, so you can enjoy the very best of cinema from around the world at an affordable price.

Sign up today and verify your age online, and you can start enjoying discounted tickets immediately.

Join the **BFI mailing list** for regular programme updates. Not yet registered? Create a new account at www.bfi.org.uk/signup

was based on Arnold Ridley and Bernard Merivale's play *The Wrecker*, and recycled spectacular train footage from a 1928 film version.

That Hitchcock and Launder-Gilliat were independently enamoured of railway settings was auspicious for their collaboration on *The Lady Vanishes*. But it nearly didn't happen. Launder brought White's novel to Gainsborough Pictures in 1936. The American Roy William Neill signed on to direct Launder and Gilliat's adaptation and a second unit was dispatched to Yugoslavia. The production was closed down when the authorities in Belgrade objected to the script. When Hitchcock inherited it in 1937, he suggested the hotel opening and the climactic shoot-out, which Gilliat worked in. 'I think this is the only case of Hitchcock taking over a script completed for another director,' he said.

But Hitchcock was not the film's sole auteur. 'Matters of ascription are far from simple,' Bruce Babington notes in his book on the writers, citing how the clue leading to the unmasking of the police chief in their *Seven Sinners* screenplay was lifted from the revelation of the arch-criminal in *The 39 Steps*. Launder and Gilliat and Charles Bennett, writer or co-writer of the five Hitchcock films before *The Lady Vanishes*, were incensed when *The New Yorker* reported in 1938 that the director was responsible for '99.4 per cent' of his pictures. The screenplays of *The Lady Vanishes* and Carol Reed's *Night Train to Munich*, Babington says, 'are highly structured prototypes for the directors marked indelibly by the wit and ethos of the writers. Even such definitively 'Hitchcockian' elements as the oneiric episodes unleashed by the flowerpot falling on Iris' head are present in the scenario, even if we feel that Hitchcock worked them in ways that were highly characteristic.'

It's clear that the sparkling screwball interaction between Iris and Gilbert was, verbally at least, the work of Launder and Gilliat, seeded as it was in *Rome Express* and *Seven Sinners*. The elegant repartee they wrote for Edmund Lowe and Constance Cummings in *Seven Sinners* was modelled on the romantic sparring in *The Thin Man* and, presumably, *It Happened One Night* (1934) and *Twentieth Century* (1934), the most acerbic of Hollywood train movies. The intertextual relationship between *The 39 Steps* and *The Lady Vanishes* doesn't simplify matters since, as Babington asserts, 'Launder and Gilliat's relationship with Hitchcock was a complex, lingering one, involving mutual debts and borrowings.' Hitchcock's signature is indelible, however. The films share the Hitchcockian MacGuffin of a coded tune. Iris' suggestion that a scream she and Gilbert hear maybe a train whistle hearkens to the match cut in *The 39 Steps*. Gilbert, like Hannay, climbs from one compartment to another outside the train. And his quick impersonations echo Hannay's use of different identities – including milkman, mechanic and politician.

Hitchcock, of course, was responsible for the rhythmic flow of the film, the note-perfect performances and the pleasing shifts in mood. All this was absent from Launder and Gilliat's *Night Train to Munich*, a leaden thriller about a British agent impersonating a Nazi officer in which director Carol Reed squanders both the train sequence and Margaret Lockwood, cast as the daughter of a German scientist. Not even the return of Charters and Caldicott, with their dry public-school badinage, can save it. Effortlessly appealing, Gilbert and Iris – who plan to marry and avoid trains – should have returned like *The Thin Man*'s Nick and Nora Charles with their own mystery franchise, but it wasn't to be. The last word on *The Lady Vanishes* should go to François Truffaut. 'They show it often in Paris; sometimes I see it twice in one week,' he told Hitchcock, as if nothing were more natural.

Graham Fuller, *Sight and Sound*, January 2008